

Un-M-Othered: A Solo Performance

Sound: Silence. No background music or ambient sound.

Video (title slide): Black background with white text: *Un-M-Othered: A Story of Adoption and Patriarchy*

Video: The stage is bare and evenly lit. Liz stands at center stage, facing forward. She wears red pants and a black t-shirt that reads, "Behind every woman is a story that gave her no choice." Her arms hang loosely at her sides. She begins in stillness, rooted, before the words land.

Liz (speaking): I don't have a birth story. I never sat on my mother's lap and said, 'Tell me about the night I was born.' The night I was born is anonymous. Like the paperwork I inquired about so many years later when it was too late.

Video: She then hops toward stage left and drops into a crouch, feet flat, knees wide, arms draped loosely in front of her. Her body folds forward. From this grounded position she looks up.

Liz (speaking): I'm anonymous. My anonymity is synchronous with my inability to find answers. The paperwork is a lie.

Video: Remaining crouched, she shifts her weight and speaks again. Her hands subtly mimic the gesture of holding and unwrapping.

Liz (speaking): I don't have a birth story. Instead, I have a fiction, a fantasy, a diversion, a distraction. Like a pretty present. Perfectly wrapped, tied neatly with a bow and a card that reads: be grateful for so much.

Video: She rises slowly to stand. As she speaks she turns away from the audience, her torso curls inward slightly, arms crossing gently as if holding something in.

Liz (speaking): I swallow myself in order to keep the illusion. The present is too pretty, too perfect to need to unwrap.

Video: She steps to face stage right. Her body is still, looking toward the imagined hospital.

Liz (speaking): I don't have a birth story. I don't know who I saw. Did she get to hold me when I meant the world for the first time? When I left. The only home I ever knew—her womb—to enter into anonymity. An anomaly analogous to an antagonism.

Video: She turns to face the audience again with arms outstretched on either side. She pauses.

Liz (speaking): I am anonymous, like the paperwork that negates my origins in favor of secrets, in favor of false truths, in favor of pretending. I don't have a birth certificate or a photograph. I couldn't sit on my mother's lap and say, 'Show me when I was in your belly.'

Video: Both hands go to her belly as she stands still upstage left center.

Liz (speaking): I am anonymous. My anonymity is synchronous with my inability to relax, to breathe, to trust, to sleep.

Video: She leans forward slightly and then straightens and lifts both arms, bent at the elbows, palms up, in a posture of offering. Her gaze lifts upward. Her hands come together at her chest in a prayer gesture.

Liz (speaking): I'm supposed to be a gift, a blessing, God's plan. An answer to a prayer.

Video: Her hands remain in prayer position as she speaks directly to the audience.

Liz (speaking): I swallow myself in order to keep the illusion. My reality exists because of someone else's fantasy. My life made possible by the pain of separation.

Video: She takes a small step to the side with one foot. Her hands drop to her belly. Her voice softens. She points to herself.

Liz (speaking): I never once doubted that I would find her, so that she would know, and I might feel more whole. My body is a war zone.

Video: As she says the line, she throws her body forcefully to the floor, landing on her left side with her arms supporting her as she looks up toward the ceiling. She stays still for a moment, collapsing on the floor, before her right arm goes to her head and her legs bend at the knees toward her torso.

Liz (speaking): Trauma lives in every cell.

Video: She rolls onto her left side with knees bent and parted as her right hand extends out as if bracing for something. She rolls onto her backside and scoots backwards a little bit with her face turned upstage, then rolls onto her left hip with her legs bent to her right side and her right hand at the side of her head, left hand slightly extended toward the audience.

Liz (speaking): I won't see or feel or heal for many years.

Video: She pauses briefly, gets up onto her knees and leans toward stage left and cocks her head as if looking for something. Her left arm reaches down and she is supported by her fingertips, her right arm bends at the elbow on her right side pointing up.

Liz (speaking): Monochopsis. The subtle but persistent feeling of being out of place is mine.

Video: Her right hand goes to her chest. Her arms wrap around her in a hug.

Liz (speaking): Shrouding me like a blanket. A fog of its own kind.

Video: She leans forward with arms still wrapped around her torso.

Liz (speaking): I am bound by my body. My brain on high alert. The pain would be excruciating if I could feel it.

Video: She shifts back up to her knees sitting back slightly with her right hand at her belly and her left hand outstretched toward the audience.

Liz (speaking): It's misplaced. I become misaligned, misled.

Video: She twists her torso toward stage right and makes a semicircle with her arms as if holding an empty space.

Liz (speaking): Screaming in silence because I can't find the words.

Video: Her voice intensifies slightly and she rises up on her knees bringing both hands toward her torso one at chest height and the other at her belly.

Liz (speaking): I can't find myself.

Video: Liz stands upright at center stage, facing the audience. Her hands are relaxed by her sides. She lifts her right hand and gently taps and then looks into her pants pocket, emphasizing the metaphor.

Liz (speaking): I carry grief in my pocket. To stay safe there in the dark.

Video: She looks up at the audience. Her shoulders are slightly curved inward. Her right hand again is flat on the outside of her pocket and her left hand is resting above her belly button.

Liz (speaking): No one really knows. It's there. Even I don't know. Because I've never been able to name it.

Video: Her left hand moves to her left hip and she looks down into her pocket.

Liz (speaking): Grief is my silent burden. Stuffed deep in my pocket. Hidden from view. I can't see it. But I carry it with me.

Video: Her hands move down her right leg as if the pocket and the grief are deep down. She is bent at the waist looking at the audience.

Liz (speaking): And it surrounds me in sadness for something I can't explain.

Video: She brings her hands up toward her waist at the right hip, one clasped over the other. There is a pause. She points toward downstage left.

Liz (speaking): I carry poems in my pocket.

Video: She moves to kneel downstage left as if reading the book of poems. Her right hand lifts again slightly, then drops. Her voice is steady. She looks up at the audience and then looks down to point at the imaginary page.

Liz (speaking): They tell me the things I need to know. About my grief and my sadness. They tell the truth that sits so heavy on my heart. But I am blind to that truth.

Video: She points to herself and then the poems.

Liz (speaking): These poems are my secret. I have to keep them close. Stuffed away so that no one will know how many questions I have...

Video: She looks toward the audience and then toward stage right and then back toward the audience as she continues. Her voice tightens slightly, her posture softening with the weight of the words.

Liz (speaking): ...so that no one will know how confused I am about who I am, who that mother is, who gave me away, and why we don't ever talk about it.

Video: She remains kneeling downstage left, hands raised as if they are holding a book before lowering her arms slowly, as she finishes looking directly at the audience.

Liz (speaking): These poems are my secret release, helping me feel less bruised, but only for as long as my pen moves across the page.

Video (closing slide): Black background with white text: Written & Performed by Liz DeBetta; Voice Coaching & Direction by Jeremy Sortore

Cast

Written & Performed by: Dr. Liz DeBetta

Voice Coaching & Direction by: Jeremy Sortore